to them—from polite pleas and moral suasion to strident demands—as we sought both equality and equity. The fact that we can now speak of the rights of all oppressed groups and not the condescension of privileges generously bequeathed to women shows how far we have come from the early discourse of how entitled men should behave towards those around them.

Despite all that we have gained, there is surely none among us who will say our battles have been conclusively won, that there is nothing more that we need and deserve. Saini suggests that the patriarchy is vulnerable and calls on us to create new paradigms of thought and action if we want to upturn it. I believe that our new narratives have begun. We have understood that the patriarchy is responsible for far greater aggressions and oppressions than those against women alone. Our new strength, renewed energy and paradigm shifts will lie in a wider collective resistance, in solidarities that work across boundaries of hierarchy, gender and identity. In fact, our enemy is the same. ■

Arshia Sattar

burdens of gratitude, or the kind of love that becomes a demand as much as a refuge. Her characters veer into religious rapture and magical realism. A notable portrait is the woman in 'The Walls', who follows the code of the *taravad*, with all its privilege-bred corruptions. She is bold enough to speak truth within the walls, and at the same time, she is false to her lover. In every way, she is mistress of those labyrinths of patriarchy.

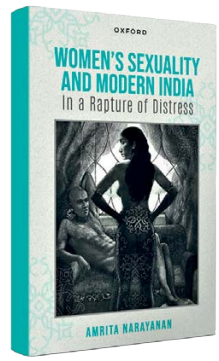
Manasi's women, if we may judge from this small sample, are not all, or even mostly, victims. She writes into them the power to jump off the track and barrel towards new uncertainties. Some run into hallucinations and some run into madness, but they remain the agents of their own future. ■

Latha Anantharaman

BOOKS

Modern LOVE

Amrita Narayanan's *Women's Sexuality and Modern India* maps how individual Indian women locate their sexuality in a patriarchal framework



WOMEN'S SEXUALITY AND MODERN INDIA
In a Rapture of Distress
by Amrita Narayanan
OXFORD UNIVERSITY PRESS
₹1,795; 224 pages

In this book, the author—an internationally renowned psychotherapist based in Goa—compiles stories, derived from a set of interviews conducted with, and regarding the sexual lives of, a small sample of volunteers, primarily privileged upper-caste and upper-class women from the northwestern axis of the country, ranging from Uttar Pradesh to Maharashtra, with a few similar South Indians thrown in. Eastern women are conspicuous by their absence. Indeed, eastern India is the unspoken other in this book, represented only by Rabindranath Tagore's teenage indiscretions (and a couple of extracts from his work), 'flying prostitutes' of Sonagachhi and Mimi Chakraborty and Nusrat Jahan wearing pantsuits in Parliament.

Right away, therefore, the 'India' whose sexuality is being mapped is a partial one; one that underlies a certain political construction that has been in the ascendant in this country since 2014 at least. Narayanan seems to be asking the valid question, what is Bhakt Bharat like in the bedroom? However, the answers she presents are a bit problematic.

Narayanan compiles stories derived from a set of interviews conducted with, and regarding the sexual lives of, a small sample of volunteers

Narayanan comes from the same cohort that she is studying, although she would probably place herself closer to the 'liberated' end of the spectrum. This gives her an insider's insight into her interviewee's problems, but it also risks a failure to see beyond their cultural context or to place it in a convincing comparativist framework. Here, one could counter-argue that she is not an anthropologist and is under no obligation to distinguish between the emic and etic aspects of her findings.

Finally, the standard of editing of this book has hit new lows. I never thought I would see the construction 'Mahabarata' in a book edited for Indians by Indians. This is definitely a typo and not a deliberately chosen variant because the title appears correctly in other places. In the last third of the book, the typos average about one per page.

As for the stories themselves, well, they are mostly what you'd expect. Narayanan tries to repackage the sexual acting-out of some of her respondents as a backhanded liberation, but it doesn't really hit the mark. ■

Rimi B. Chatterjee